

Machine Civilization

Yixiong Wang

The Hong Kong University of Science
and Technology (Guangzhou)
Guangzhou, China
yixiongcreagan@gmail.com

Jia-Qi Shi

The Hong Kong University of Science
and Technology (Guangzhou)
Guangzhou, China
jshi144@connect.hkust-gz.edu.cn

Hourun Wang

The Hong Kong University of Science
and Technology (Guangzhou)
Guangzhou, China
hwang236@connect.hkust-gz.edu.cn

Yufeng Zeng

The Hong Kong University of Science
and Technology (Guangzhou)
Guangzhou, China
yzeng683@connect.hkust-gz.edu.cn

Chen Liang

The Hong Kong University of Science
and Technology (Guangzhou)
Guangzhou, China
chenliang2@hkust-gz.edu.cn

ACM Reference Format:

Yixiong Wang, Jia-Qi Shi, Hourun Wang, Yufeng Zeng, and Chen Liang. 2025. Machine Civilization. In *SIGGRAPH Asia 2025 Art Gallery (SA Art Gallery '25)*, December 15–18, 2025, Hong Kong, Hong Kong. ACM, New York, NY, USA, 1 page. <https://doi.org/10.1145/3757368.3765549>

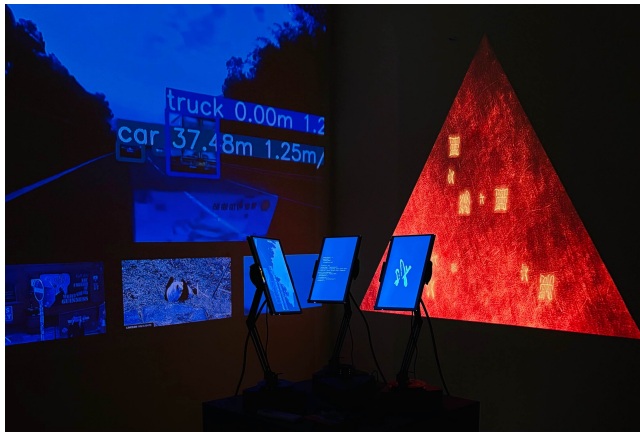


Figure 1: Machine Civilization

1 ABSTRACT

The origins of civilization have always fascinated us. The birth of script is often seen as the very beginning of human culture. From pictographs to modern typography, from recording facts to expressing thoughts, writing has preserved knowledge and defined history, and also carried our sense of self and subjectivity. Today, with the rapid development of artificial intelligence and autonomous machines, we may be approaching the dawn of another form of civilization: machine civilization.

Permission to make digital or hard copies of all or part of this work for personal or classroom use is granted without fee provided that copies are not made or distributed for profit or commercial advantage and that copies bear this notice and the full citation on the first page. Copyrights for third-party components of this work must be honored. For all other uses, contact the owner/author(s).

SA Art Gallery '25, Hong Kong, Hong Kong

© 2025 Copyright held by the owner/author(s).

ACM ISBN 979-8-4007-1883-0/25/12

<https://doi.org/10.1145/3757368.3765549>

We built an autonomous system that observes the world through diverse machine perspectives, such as robotic vacuum cleaners, satellites, drones, real-time global surveillance cameras, microscopes, and more. Like the earliest chroniclers of human history, these machines roam through cities with curious “eyes,” continuously identifying, collecting, and recording elements of nature, human artifacts, scenes, behaviors, and microscopic worlds. These data are no longer translated into human-readable texts but are instead fed into a “council” of AI. From a non-human perspective, multiple agents with divergent models analyze the visuals, engage in discussions, and, drawing inspiration from the evolution of human writing, generate the first forms of machine script. Just as early humans carved cuneiform, these AI-generated scripts are ultimately engraved onto metal stelae that pay homage to the pyramid.

Taking “the emergence of language as the beginning of civilization” as a point of departure, this work imagines a scenario where non-human intelligence carries its own civilization by generating its own script. Our aim is not to claim that AI possesses “consciousness,” but to use this speculative framework to explore how meaning, agency, and sovereignty shift in an age of intelligent machines and human-machine symbiosis. As Wittgenstein once said, the limits of language are the limits of thought. In this era of technological rise, if the boundaries of language are blurred and reshaped, could our cognition undergo a fundamental transformation?